Distant Close Reading: Measuring Whether Literatures Cohere

Introduction

A familiar theme in any field's discussions about itself, including organizational theory, is whether its literatures cohere, that is, whether they refer to a stable set of concepts or categories. Pfeffer (1993) lamented that paradigm fragmentation weakens the field while Van Maanen (1995) replied that the field's plural styles of theorizing are a strength. More broadly, Collins (1998) argued that productive fields organize around a few rival positions, while others fragment and balkanize into independent camps. Which situation a literature is in is an empirical question, yet no instrument measures it while engaging closely with the ideas.

Bibliometric measures such as keywords or shared references capture co-occurrence, not whether the ideas expressed are compatible. Literature reviews address coherence qualitatively and are usually written by a single author or a like-minded group reading through one lens. The coherence such reviews report cannot be separated from the readings that produced it.

This proposal describes a measure of interpretive coherence, which asks whether a literature's understanding of its constructs survives being read in deliberately different ways, judged against how much any single way of reading varies on its own.

Prior Work

Hermeneutics has long held that different lenses yield different readings (Gadamer, 1960/1989; Ricoeur, 1970). Distant Close Reading (DCR) turns this insight into a repeatable instrument for measuring conceptual coherence. Human readers cannot encounter the same work twice as if for the first time because each reading is shaped by the accumulated experience of previous encounters. Large language models, by contrast, can be instantiated as readers that follow a written method anyone can inspect, apply a predefined theoretical lens, and see each document as if for the first time, repeatably.

In the digital humanities, Moretti's (2013) distant reading deliberately moved away from close reading for scale, focusing instead on graphs, maps and trees of texts and the words within them. DCR retains close reading but scales it. Inter-rater reliability measures agreement among coders applying the same scheme and treats disagreement as error (Krippendorff, 2004). DCR measures agreement among silicon readers applying deliberately different schemes and treats disagreement as evidence about the literature.

Method

Readers. Three reader personas and two reworded controls read the same passages, each producing a method-specific reading:

- *Structural:* what must be true for each claim to hold (premises and dependencies).
- *Operational:* what each claim commits one to observing, and what would falsify it.
- *Genealogical:* which earlier formulations the understanding draws on, revises or replaces.
- *Reworded readers* ("shams" in the code): the structural method phrased differently (plain and formal), a check that method, not wording, drives divergence.

Readers see only passages, a document ID and a year, never authors or titles.

Characterization vs. stance. Each reading is reduced to 3–7 short standalone claims about what the document takes the construct to be (characterization), plus a separate label for whether it endorses,

extends, contests or merely invokes the account it engages (stance). Coherence is computed on characterization only, because mere contestation is not evidence of incoherence. Camps that disagree with one another but describe a given construct the same way fundamentally share an understanding.

Measurement. Agreement between claim sets is scored with natural language inference (entailment vs. contradiction), not word similarity. Every comparison is set against a baseline with the same reader reading the same document afresh. Only divergence above this baseline counts as disagreement.

Editors. Two editors, one synthesizing and one adversarial, read across all readings of a corpus and classify the literature:

	Shared characterization	**No shared characterization**
Shared stance	Settled	Incoherent consensus
Divided stance	Coherent contestation	Fragmentation

The editors' qualitative judgments are compared with the measures. Following Collins's (1998) law of small numbers, a coherently contested field should resolve into a few stable rival positions, while an incoherent one fragments and balkanizes into independent camps.

Proof of Concept

We built a working pipeline and ran it in full on two organizational literatures, transaction cost economics (TCE) and legitimacy. Every rule and persona was committed to Git before any results were generated.

Corpus. A mechanical rule over OpenAlex selected articles in six journals (AMR, AMJ, ASQ, *Organization Science*, SMJ, JMS) that cite a literature's anchor works and name its construct, ranked by citations.

Corpus	**Anchors**	**Documents**	**Passages**
Legitimacy	Suchman (1995); Deephouse & Suchman (2008); Suddaby, Bitektine & Haack (2017)	23	184
Transaction cost economics (TCE)	Williamson (1975, 1981, 1985, 1991)	19	148
Manipulation check: corporate governance	Jensen & Meckling (1976)	5	36

Manipulation check. We added five agency-theory papers to the TCE pool. They use "governance" for how owners and boards control managers; TCE uses it for how transactions are organized, across markets, hybrids and hierarchies and within them. Adding them should therefore lower coherence. Passages are capped at 8 per document and selected by construct terms.

Record. The anonymized repository (https://anonymous.4open.science/r/distant-close-reading-EDA9/) holds all code, frozen prompts, extracted claims, measures and a log of every design change. Technical Appendix A7 lists its contents.

Runs. Claude Sonnet 5.5 read every document five times with each persona, and the legitimacy and TCE documents five times with each reworded reader. This produced 1,125 readings, each reduced to claims. Each editor judged each corpus condition once per reader repetition, plus three repeats on fixed input to measure editor variance. All 2,292 calls succeeded; 0.4% of extractions failed to parse and were excluded.

Measurement. We compared about 7,100 unique claims with about 860,000 NLI judgments (DeBERTa-large-MNLI; He et al., 2021), within documents (reader vs. reader, and repeat vs. repeat) and between documents (corpus coherence).

Validation

Four checks test DCR's method choices.

1. **Using NLI to score agreement.** Before any reading, we tested two ways to score whether claims agree on 15 author-vetted pairs with known answers. The pairs were either opposed claims worded alike or equivalent claims worded differently. Embedding similarity, the usual way to compare texts, got the ordering backwards (AUC = 0.18; chance is 0.5). Natural language inference (NLI) got it right (AUC = 1.00), so DCR uses NLI.
2. **Divergence exceeds noise.** Different readers of the same document agreed less (S = 0.256, 95% CI 0.236–0.277) than one reader agreed with its own repetitions (0.325, 0.305–0.343).
3. **Method, not wording, drives divergence.** Reworded readers agreed with each other (0.309) and with the structural reader (0.319) at the noise floor, while different methods agreed less (0.256).
4. **The instrument responds to known incoherence.** Adding the governance papers lowered TCE coherence from 0.017 to −0.004. Mixed TCE–governance pairs scored lowest (−0.045), while the governance papers agreed among themselves (0.042).

Results

To our surprise, legitimacy proved more coherent than TCE (between-document agreement 0.072 vs. 0.017 with sd across reader repetitions ≤ 0.004). The difference does not depend on the word choice. Asking readers about "transaction cost economics" instead of "governance" left TCE coherence low (0.025).

TCE splits. Grouped after the fact, Williamson's works agree with one another (mean 0.128, 10 pairs), as do relational-governance papers (0.109, 3 pairs). Between these camps, agreement falls to 0.011, near the TCE average. Coherence collapses because "governance" means different things:

Document	Governance is…	Unit	Criterion or mechanism
Williamson (1991)	One of three discrete structures: market, hybrid, hierarchy	The transaction	Efficiency, matched to asset specificity
Ring & Van de Ven (1994)	A developmental process of negotiation, commitment and execution	The relationship over time	Efficiency and equity; trust
Eisenhardt & Schoonhoven (1996)	A firm's strategic choice to ally, not theorized as governance	The firm	Resource needs and social position

Agreement with Williamson falls from 0.045 (Ring & Van de Ven) to −0.104 (Eisenhardt & Schoonhoven), among the lowest in the corpus. Governance as a term is protean across the management literature.

Legitimacy fades rather than splits. Papers that theorize legitimacy agree most (Suchman, 1995 at 0.138); agreement declines among papers that invoke it as a motive, such as CSR reporting (Marquis & Qian, 2014 at 0.012). Stance was uniform with readers judging 18 of 23 documents to modify and 5 to extend the account they engage. TCE stances spread across extend (9), modify (7), contest (2) and endorse (1).

Editors are reliable but coarse. On fixed input, each editor repeated its own judgment in all 16 runs, but editors labeled 29 of 30 main runs "coherent contestation." The measures, not the labels, distinguish the literatures. Editors did respond to the added governance papers by finding more positions (adversarial at 5.0 to 6.2 and synthesizing at 5.2 to 5.6), and the adversarial editor found 5.4 positions in legitimacy and 5.0 in TCE, within the three-to-six range Collins (1998) predicts.

Some correlation with citations. Agreement between document pairs correlated moderately with bibliographic coupling (Spearman $\rho = 0.43$ for legitimacy, 0.26 for TCE). Shared references account for part of interpretive agreement, but most of it is not visible in citation structure.

Key Risks and Limitations

- **One model family, default sampling.** All runs used Claude Sonnet 5.5 through Claude Code, which does not expose temperature. Cross-model replication is the first Stage 2 test.
- **NLI may read contrast as contradiction.** Claims about related categories (cognitive vs. pragmatic legitimacy; hierarchies vs. markets) can be scored as contradictory when both are true; a prespecified test found this in 2 of 10 such pairs. Comparisons are more robust, since all conditions are scored alike, but whether the bias affects both literatures equally needs Stage 2 testing.
- **Extraction normalizes voice.** Stripping method vocabulary lets the measures compare content, but it could also make readings converge artificially. The reworded controls and the noise floor bound this effect.
- **A small corpus.** Forty-seven documents make the results checkable by experts but limit generality. Scaling to much larger corpora is the Stage 2 test.
- **NLI's domain knowledge.** The one gold-pair error ("bounded rationality" vs. "people cannot foresee every contingency") shows a general-purpose NLI model can miss inferences specialists make.
- **Silicon readers may recognize famous papers.** Blinding readers to authors and titles limits recall from memory but cannot prevent it.

Stage 2

This proposal shows that conceptual coherence can be measured across interpretive differences. Stage 2 will examine scalability and robustness.

1. **Cross-model replication.** Rerun the full design on other closed and open-weights models with controlled sampling. Stability across model families would show the method is not model-specific.
2. **Scale.** Extend to 200 or more documents per literature, and to further literatures expected to differ in coherence, such as institutional logics and organizational identity.
3. **The cluster-count test.** Test whether literatures resolve into a few rival positions, as Collins (1998) predicts for healthy fields, or balkanize into independent camps, as TCE appears to.
4. **A reader library.** This prototype used three readers. We will add others (for example, contrastive and temporal) and invite the community to contribute more.
5. **Expert-labeled claims.** Build a larger gold set with domain experts to calibrate NLI for organizational theory.
6. **Design choices, refined with the editors.** Construct terms, reader sets and editor roles are parameters we expect to refine at the workshop.

Discussion

If DCR proves reliable, coherence in literatures becomes something organizational scholars can measure rather than assert. The debate over whether the field is fragmented (Pfeffer, 1993) or productively plural (Van Maanen, 1995) can be assessed repeatably and systematically, and Collins's (1998) distinction between rivalry and balkanization becomes testable.

Three practical shifts follow. Reviews can report how robust their synthesis is to the way it was read, much as quantitative work reports robustness checks. Contested constructs can be diagnosed, so that a field disputing a shared construct can be told apart from one using a single word for different things. Lastly, theory building gains a map of where literatures show genuine agreement rather than nominal similarity.

The broader shift is from literature synthesis to literature deliberation. Disagreement is not necessarily incoherence; it becomes a property of a field that can be observed, compared and tracked over time.

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